From ~~*rough*~~ to Q1-ready: a polishing workflow

Polishing Your Draft Article Using AI Tools · Winning Journal Writing Workshop 2026 · UTM & HCMUT · Assoc. Prof. Dr. Mohd Shahizan Othman

	Stage	Starter prompt or action	Check yourself
1	**Human-written draft** Write the ideas, data and argument yourself.	`No AI. Your ideas, your analysis.`	Is every claim yours and supported by your data?
2	**Structural review** Check the order and completeness of each section.	`“Review my abstract against background, aim, method, findings, contribution. Do not rewrite it.”`	Gap, objectives and contribution stated explicitly?
3	**Language review** Improve grammar, clarity and flow.	`“Improve clarity and grammar without changing the meaning or adding claims. Keep technical terms. Explain each change.”`	Meaning, numbers and construct names unchanged?
4	**Reference verification** Confirm every reference exists and supports your claim.	`Never ask AI for citations. Check each DOI with Crossref.`	Each source opened and read?
5	**Peer or expert review** A colleague or supervisor reads the full draft.	`No AI.`	Would an expert in your field agree with each claim?
6	**Simulated peer review** Anticipate the questions reviewers will ask.	`“Act as a critical reviewer for [JOURNAL]. List major and minor concerns.”`	Have you addressed the major concerns?
7	**Final human sign-off** Read the whole manuscript as it will be submitted.	`Search for prompt leftovers such as “Certainly, here is”.`	AI disclosure written, references verified, all authors approved?

Every prompt should say
Role · field · journal · task · “do not change meaning” · “do not add citations” · British or American English · explain the changes.

Watch for
Fabricated references · changed meaning · correlation turned into causation · terminology drift · altered numbers · “delve”, “pivotal”, “intricate”.

Keep a record
Log each AI-assisted edit (tool, purpose, section, decision). Use it to write your disclosure statement.

Core principle. Every AI output is checked by a human. Every reference is verified against the original source. Every use of AI is disclosed in line with the journal's policy.

Check each publisher's current AI policy before submitting. Tools, prompts and guides are on the workshop website.